the Dr Paul and Prof. VijayRaghavan-led team's estimates, for a surge of 1,50,000 patients on a given day during the peak, about 30,000 people would require hospitalization due to moderate and severe disease. Further, they derived that using the estimate of 15,000 beds which would be required for 1,000 new admissions, approximately 4.5 lakh beds would be needed—out of which 1,50,000 would have to be ICU beds and 3,00,000 would have to be non-ICU beds with provision for oxygen. This number was 40 per cent of all existing bed capacity in India—which meant that 40 per cent of all beds in the country would have to be augmented for COVID-19 patients only.

The first step to be taken was to stop the exchange of travellers from COVID-19-hit countries and airports. India would have to suspend all visas, except a few select categories like diplomatic and employment visas. A recommendation on the lines was made by the Cabinet secretary which further trickled down to the Empowered Group of Ministers, who agreed to green light the decision in their sixth meeting, under the chairmanship of the Union health minister.[10] Starting 13 March, the suspension of visas came into effect. Indian nationals arriving from countries with high caseloads, such as China, Italy, Iran, the Republic of Korea, France, Spain and Germany after 15 February 2020 would be quarantined for a minimum of 14 days. Indians were also strongly advised to avoid non-essential travel.

After the intensity of the projected peak figures, it was clear to everyone present in the meeting with Dr Paul and Dr VijayRaghavan at the PMO that locking down the country for a limited number of weeks in order to break the chain of transmission was the only solution. The chief economic advisor, along with other economic experts would have to put together a report on the impact of complete economic shutdown. In the month of February, the total Goods and Services Tax (GST) collected was ₹1.05 lakh crore, consistent with collections of the past quarter. Based on those numbers, India would need to evaluate the GDP and growth impact and draw up financial measures which would help individuals and businesses sustain.

Only a day before India announced visa suspension, the WHO had announced that COVID-19 was a global pandemic.[11] With states beginning to shut down public spaces, offices and schools and the risk of the contagion levelling up to community spread, the business sentiment was at an all-time low. On 12 March, following the 10 per cent Dow Jones crash in